# The State of Bootstrapped SaaS

*An executive analysis of 1,000 revenue-transparent startups*

This report analyzes the full TrustMRR public dataset — 1,000 independently operated, mostly founder-led software businesses that voluntarily disclose live revenue. It is not one company's financials; it is a market-wide snapshot of how the indie and micro-SaaS economy is actually performing today.

| $15.9M | 78.4% | $134.4M | 83.8% |
|---|---|---|---|
| Total 30-day revenue | Startups earning revenue | Trailing 12-month revenue | Revenue held by top 10% |

Scope: 1,000 startups on the TrustMRR directory · Snapshot frozen July 30, 2026 · Revenue figures sourced via connected payment processors (Stripe, RevenueCat, Polar, Paddle, and others)

HOW THIS DATASET WORKS

# Reading the TrustMRR dataset as a system

The workbook is one wide table split into five logical blocks. Each startup is one row; the blocks connect on record_id.

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | **Identity & geography** | record_id, name, website, country, X followers |
| 2 | **Revenue & payments** | processor, 30d / 3m / 12m / all-time revenue, 30d growth |
| 3 | **Engagement** | MRR, MRR growth, active subscriptions, site visitors |
| 4 | **Classification** | pricing model, audience, category tags, domain authority |
| 5 | **M&A listing** | for-sale flag, asking price, revenue multiple |

**Data quality — field coverage across all 1,000 rows**

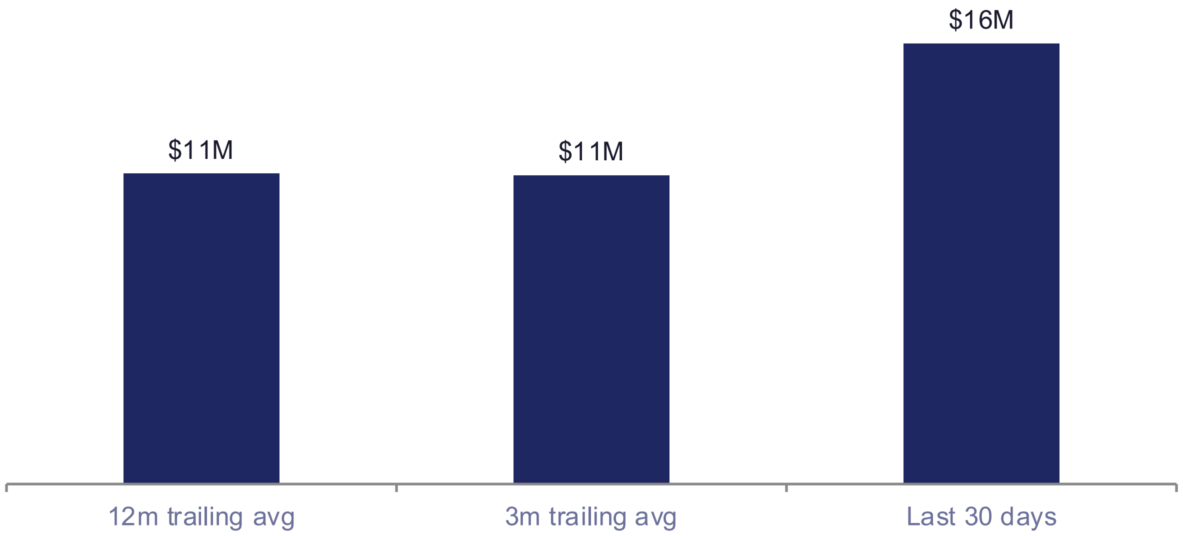
| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| **100%** | **95%** | **72%** | **37%** |
| Revenue & payment provider | Follower count | Country | Category tag |

*Limitation: even on a platform built around radical transparency, only 37% of founders have tagged a category and 72% disclose a country — treat category- and geography-level findings as directional, not exhaustive.*

# Revenue is accelerating — but concentrated

| $15.9M | $33.4M | $134.4M | $331.8M |
| --- | --- | --- | --- |
| Last 30 days | Last 3 months | Last 12 months | All-time (cumulative) |

Run-rate momentum: 30-day vs trailing averages



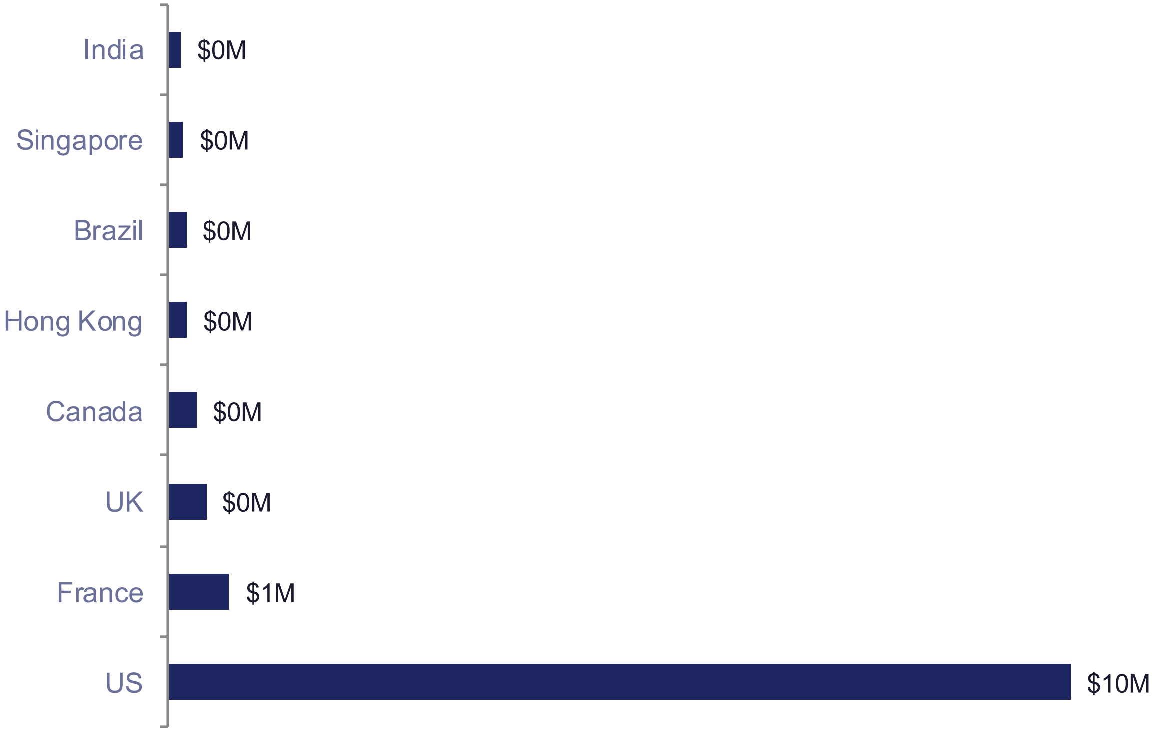

### What's driving it

- The market's 30-day run-rate ($15.9M) sits 43% above its trailing 3-month monthly average — the ecosystem is growing, not flat.
- That lift isn't one company: excluding the single largest earner, the market is still up 17% over its trailing average.
- Among revenue-generating startups, growth is genuinely split — 337 growing, 302 declining, 133 flat in the last 30 days. This is a bifurcating market, not a rising tide.

GEOGRAPHIC PERFORMANCE

# The US anchors the market; value is thin elsewhere

Top countries by 30-day revenue




## Business read

**61%** of all revenue comes from the US (246 companies) — the center of gravity for this market by a wide margin.

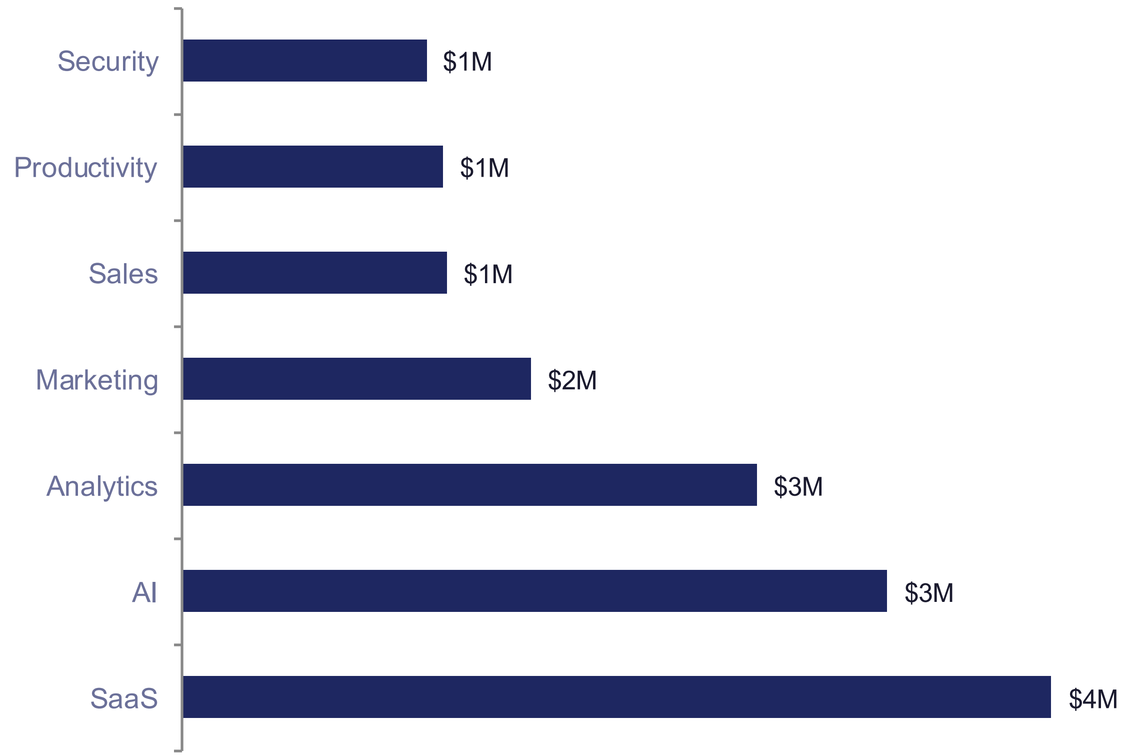
**$21.5K** average per company in Singapore (n=8) and $26.4K in Lithuania (n=4) — tiny cohorts monetizing far above the norm.

**57 vs $2.5K** India has the largest non-Western cohort (57 startups) but the lowest average revenue per company — a long tail of early-stage builders.

**28.5%** of startups don't disclose a country — treat geographic totals as a floor, not a ceiling.

# Volume leaders aren't the same as value leaders

Top categories by total 30-day revenue




**Reframed by revenue PER company**

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **Security** | $91.7K avg | 12 companies |
| **Recruiting & HR** | $64.3K avg | 9 companies |
| **Sales tools** | $47.7K avg | 25 companies |
| **Analytics** | $37.0K avg | 70 companies |
| **AI (for comparison)** | $16.1K avg | 198 companies |

*Security, Recruiting & HR, and Sales-tooling startups are small in number but monetize far above the crowded SaaS/AI/Mobile-Apps segments, where a long tail of near-zero earners pulls the average down.*

# A handful of startups carry the market

**38.5%**
**Top 5 startups**
of all 30-day revenue

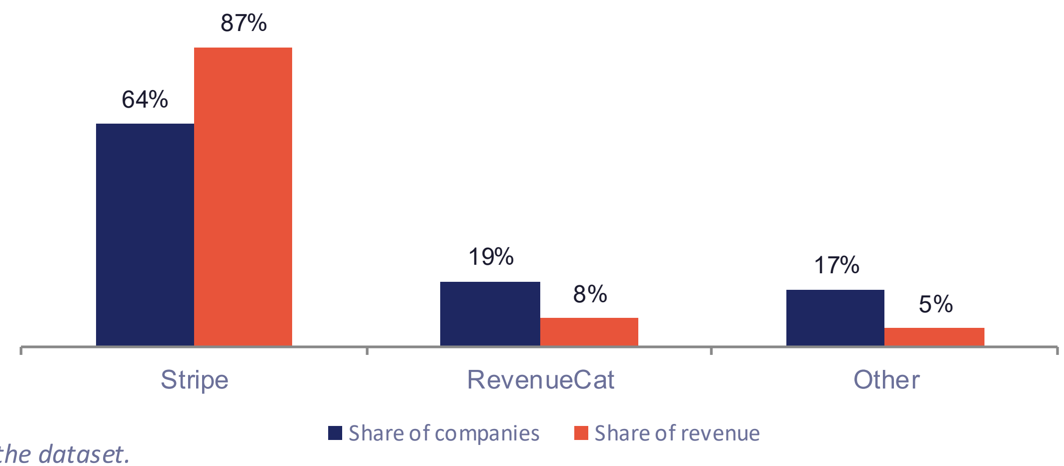
**48.6%**
**Top 1% (10 startups)**
of all 30-day revenue

**83.8%**
**Top 10% (100 startups)**
of all 30-day revenue

### Top 5 companies by 30-day revenue

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| stan | $2.84M | 101,590 subs |
| brand-on-demand-inc | $984.5K | 3,631 subs |
| stack-influence | $868.3K | 55 subs |
| stealth-company-17 | $857.6K | 325 subs |
| comp-ai | $575.3K | 50 subs |

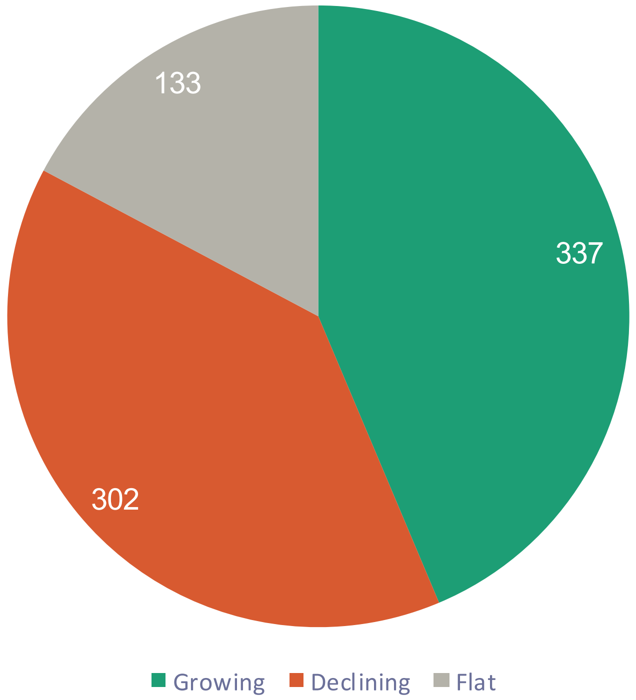
### Payment processor as a quality signal




*Stripe-backed startups are 64% of the population but 87% of revenue — the strongest single quality signal in the dataset.*

# Momentum is real, but split down the middle

30-day growth status (revenue-generating startups)




### What the split means

- 772 revenue-generating startups report a 30-day growth figure; the median is 0.0% — the typical company is neither expanding nor shrinking.
- This is a genuinely bifurcating market: 337 companies are actively growing while 302 are actively declining. Aggregate market growth is being delivered by a subset of winners, not broad participation.
- Follower count shows no reliable relationship to revenue: the single most-followed startup in the dataset (366K followers) reported $0 in 30-day revenue, while several six-figure earners had comparatively small followings.
- The all-time-to-30-day ratio ($331.8M all-time vs $15.9M this month) reflects a market with real accumulated history, not a wave of brand-new entrants.

KEY BUSINESS INSIGHTS

# What the numbers are really saying

1

### Winner-take-most, even at the indie level

The top 1% of startups (10 companies) capture 48.6% of market revenue — a power-law distribution typically associated with venture-backed markets, now visible in the bootstrapped world too. Peer benchmarks should use medians, not averages.

2

### Payment processor is a stronger signal than category

Stripe-backed startups outperform every category grouping: 64% of the population, 87% of the revenue. Processor choice likely correlates with business maturity and seriousness more than any self-reported tag does.

3

### Audience ≠ revenue

Social following and monetization are decoupled. Treat follower counts as a marketing-reach metric only — never as a proxy for financial health in diligence or benchmarking.

4

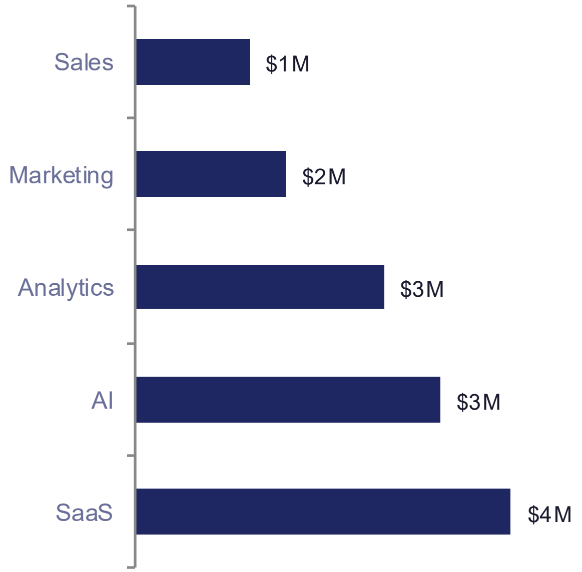
### A real acquisition market exists — and it's cheap

262 startups (26.2%) are listed for sale, totaling $86.8M in asking value. The median multiple is just 3.0x revenue — the 9.5x average is dragged up by a handful of outlier listings.

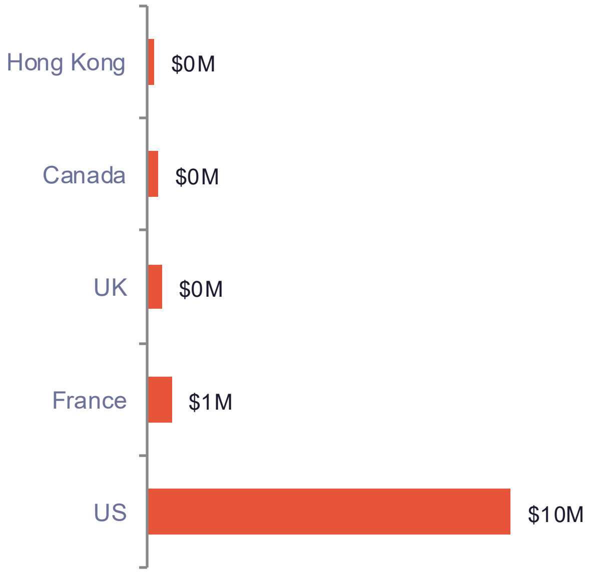
# The market in one minute

| $15.9M | 784 / 1,000 | 83.8% | 262 |
|---|---|---|---|
| 30-day revenue | earning revenue | held by top 10% | listed for sale |

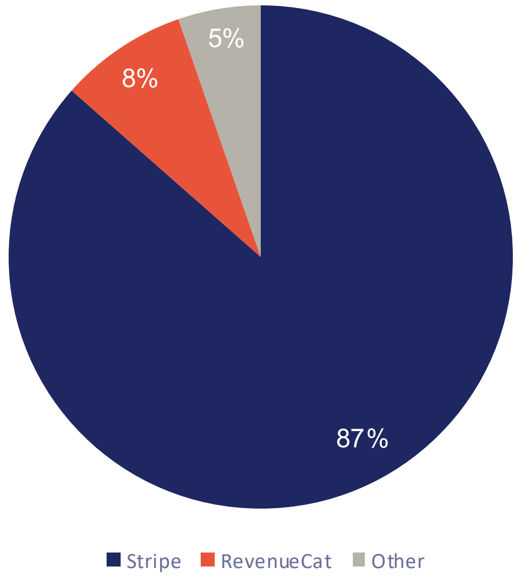
Top categories




Top countries




Revenue by processor



STRATEGIC RECOMMENDATIONS

# Where to focus next

1. **Source acquisitions from Stripe-backed, US-based SaaS / Analytics / Security startups**

   This slice consistently shows the highest realized revenue per company — the strongest evidence-based filter in the dataset.

2. **Anchor deal pricing to the 3.0x median multiple, not the 9.5x average**

   The average is dragged up by a small number of outlier listings; median is the defensible benchmark for the other 260+ listedstartups.

3. **Stop using follower count as a diligence signal**

   It shows no reliable relationship to revenue. Replace it with MRR, active subscriptions, and payment-processor identity.

4. **Push for complete category and country disclosure**

   37% category and 72% country coverage limits every downstream analysis — closing this gap materially improves market intelligence.

5. **Benchmark and support programs on medians, not averages**

   With the top 1% holding 48.6% of revenue, mean-based benchmarks overstate what a typical founder should expect.

# A healthy market with a widening gap

- $15.9M in 30-day revenue across 1,000 startups, up 43% on the trailing 3-month average — and still up 17% excluding the single largest earner.
- Revenue is winner-take-most: the top 10% of startups hold 83.8% of all revenue; the top 1% alone holds 48.6%.
- Stripe-backed startups (64% of the market) generate 87% of revenue — the single strongest quality signal available.
- Growth is genuinely split — 337 growing, 302 declining — indicating a bifurcating market, not universal momentum.
- A $86.8M acquisition market is active, with 26.2% of startups listed for sale at a median 3.0x revenue multiple.

*Bottom line: the indie/bootstrapped SaaS economy is larger and more active than its reputation suggests, but it behaves like a venture market at small scale — a handful of breakout performers concentrate the value. Treat medians, not averages, as the realistic benchmark, and use payment-processor identity — not social proof — as the leading indicator of quality.*